BORDERING STATE AND SOCIETY: COMMUNITY SCHOOLS IN ZAMBIA

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INTRODUCTION

Many rural and urban Zambian parents do not have access to government schools, and instead send children to community schools, which are built and supported by local communities. These schools emerged in the 1990s. In 2016 **more than a quarter of all primary schools were community schools** (Ministry of Education, 2016).

There is little research on the **political aspects of these schools**, although they represent fundamental changes in the border between state and society.

While there are anecdotes of community schools doing poorly in terms of learning, there is **little systematic research** to confirm this, especially at early grades.

RESEARCH QUESTIONS

Why do community schools exist and persist?

How have they been rationalized by the state and public in terms of a state/society border?

What learning outcomes result from this border, or between community and government schools?

STATE/SOCIETY BORDER

This study adopts a theoretical framework where neither state nor society are concrete or coherent entities (Rose & Mill, 1992; Abrams, 1988).

A border between state and society does not actually separate them, but produces power and legitimacy, often for the state, and the appearance of distinct entities of state and society (Mitchell, 1991).

METHODS

Mixed methods approach, using policy analysis, semi-structured interviews with state officials, NGO staff, and University faculty in Education, and Afrobarometer public opinion surveys.

Early Grade Reading and Math (EGRA/EGMA) assessments, analyzed with Hiearchical Linear Models (HLMs).

RESULTS

Community schools existed prior to the 1990s, although the state/society border was dramatically different.

Schools grew organically from 1990s, responding to economic crisis, structural adjustment, and a sustained drop in education funding.

Currently schools exist in parallel with government schools, and students perform worse in math and reading even after controlling for factors that differentiate schools.

DECREASED STATE FUNDING FOR SCHOOLING

While other African countries were impacted by economic conditions in the 1980s, Zambia was unique in its consistent reduction in government funding for education.

The "lost decades" of the 1980s-90s were typified by few schools, overcrowded classrooms, which **led to the growth of communities building their own schools.**

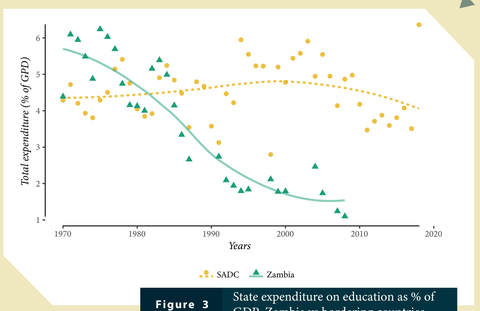


Figure 3 State expenditure on education as % of GDP, Zambia vs bordering countries

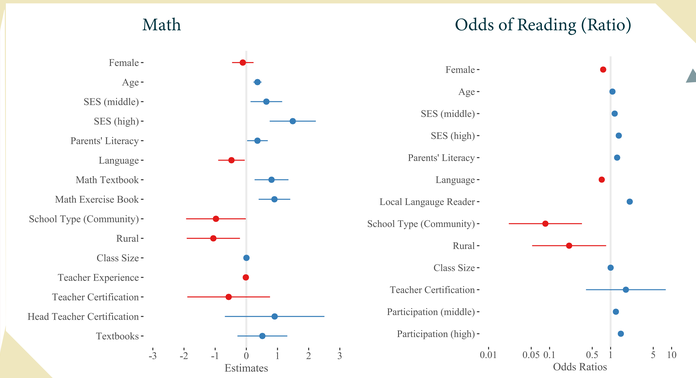


Figure 1 Regression results for Math and Reading

PUBLIC OPINION STILL SEES THE NATIONAL STATE AS THE PROVIDER OF SCHOOLING

Community schools are owned by local communities, while state policies since the 1990s emphasized that parents were also the "custodians" of government schools.

However, the majority of Zambians (81%) saw **the government was responsible for both providing schools and clinics**, and most (92%) saw **the local or national government as having the main responsibility to manage schools**.

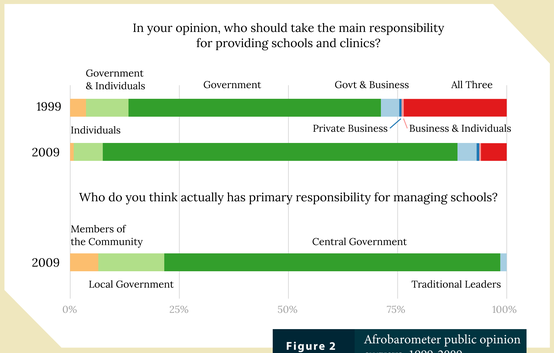


Figure 2 Afrobarometer public opinion surveys, 1999-2009

REGRESSION RESULTS

Models controlled for factors that should explain outcomes, including household socio-economic status (SES), school location and resources, and teacher experience and qualifications.

Yet community school students still performed worse in both reading and math. **School location and household SES were also strong predictors of learning outcomes.**

CONCLUSION

The Zambian public schooling system is typified by two types of schools along a state/society border: government and community.

Yet parents who send children to community schools are disproportionately tasked with keeping these schools running, managing them, and paying teachers.

Over time, the state has framed these schools as ways for communities to "own" education, but public opinion still sees the state as playing a key role.

Despite serving similar populations, community schools fare worse than government schools in math and reading.

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